Looking a Lot Like Christmas

by Jason Sheets

INTRODUCTION

Pantomime: Put a record on the record player . . .listen for a moment then begin singing as you decorate the Christmas tree.

Have yourself a Merry little Christmas
Let your hearts be light
From now on, our troubles will be out of sight

Have yourself a merry little Christmas
Make the Yuletide gay
From now on, our troubles will be miles away

Welcome to my holiday ritual. It begins with the early Christmas specials and ends with Dick Clark's Rockin' Eve. I watch by myself. Alone with a glass of egg nog. . . . Looking a Lot Like Christmas by Jason Sheets

Ever notice how the characters on Christmas specials have no family? I mean Rudolph: a loner. Charlie Brown has a whole party without his parents. Those elves may have a social network going, but rarely do you see them with their family. I'm sure they all have families. It's implied. I guess that's why I watch them each Christmas. People assume I have a family. It's implied.

So how'd I end up this way? One word: homosexuality. Or, as my sister put it, three words: "that queer thing". For 20 years, I was the straightest man in Wichita. Sure, there were hints. When my friends had sleepover parties and we'd sneak a look at *Playboy*, everyone else was mesmerized. They'd say "Whoa!", so I'd say "Whoa!" But I never really understood what all the" whoaing" was about. When *Die Hard* was big, all the other guys liked it when Bruce Willis kicked some ass. I

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liked it when the ass-kicking required ripping off his shirt. So, the thoughts were there, but that's all they were. Thoughts.

In college I hid it. I was too busy. It was always something else. A paper. A party. An intramural basketball game. Anything but the topic of romance. Anything but a blind date. Anything but addressing my weird fascination to my fraternity brother. Anything but that.

But then I met someone. Not just anyone. *The* someone that you always dream about. In my first year in the office, Tom asked me out for drinks. I didn't think it was a date. Maybe it wasn't at first. But as the seasons changed from autumn to winter to spring, I knew. And when Tom said he loved me, I had no problem loving back. OK, some problem - I was new at this. Still, I was whisked into a fantasy world. A place I could call my own.

One problem: family. Actually two sub-sets of the same problem:

1.) I always wanted a family. OK - call me short-sighted, but just as I knew I was gay, I also pictured myself with the standard wife, kids, dog, picket fence - you know the routine. Tom and I weren't exactly family Channel material.
2.) My family would be stunned. They would call a therapist, a priest, and my old high school prom date simultaneously and plot a conversion. It would be hell.

So, when I got up the strength to tell my family, 28 months later, I decided to do it with style. Pizzazz. Christmas dinner. Extended family and all. I was really wasn't going for the shock factor - I just would be damned if I'd have to give the

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spiel twice. It opened as planned: Mom fixes ham and potatoes, dad says grace, sisters complain of the fat content, grandpa states that it's good to have the family together on the holidays, and off we go on another Christmas at the Engelhans. I was ready.

"OK everyone. I wanted to tell you something. I know you all have said I should date more. I just wanted to tell you that I've met someone. Actually we've been dating for almost 3 years. I've never felt so right, so alive. His name is Tom -"

Stop. Freeze frame. You know how you learn in science class that at zero degrees Kelvin, all motion ceases? Zero degrees Kelvin - right there at the dinner table. Dad gives me a look like he should have played more football with me when I was a kid. Mom stares into space. My sisters look like I just stole their boyfriend.

Then things happen in slow motion. My aunt drops her fork into her soup. Dad says, "This is no time for sick jokes." Mom says, "Yes, it's Christmas." Grandma says, "Is Tom short for Thomasina?" Grandpa says, "I'm not listening to this" and leaves.

Dinner continues. Silent. Voiceless. And yet speaking volumes.

That night I meet up with dad in the living room. He's always been the spokesperson for the family. He certainly will be for this, too.

"Do you love him?"

"Yes."

"Does he love you?"

"Yes."

"Do you see a future with him?"

"I certainly hope so."

"Son, you've pulled the rug out from under me. What do you want me to say?

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I'm happy? I'm not. You've chosen a difficult lifestyle."

"It's not-"

"I know. I know. It's not a choice. Maybe it's not. Who's to say? But now you've forced a choice on me. My Bible says it's wrong. I can choose to accept you and reject my Bible, or I can accept the Bible and reject you. Do you understand what decision you're forcing on this family?"

I knew this was going to be difficult. I knew that. But I never dreamed of the horror of that night. Growing up, my father taught me one thing above all others: never turn your back to the Lord. And that was what he chose to do that night. Not turning his back on the Lord meant the family turning its back on me. I never went back to that house. I drove past, but never went back.

There was only one person who hadn't turned his back on me, but he did so three weeks later. He said he didn't envision a future for us. He said so in a note. My life reduced to a post-it. And then there was none.

And that's how I'm here. Uniquely myself; uniquely alone. Sure, we've got support meetings. Meetings to make us feel like we're not alone. But we are alone, often reduced to two emotions: numbness and rage.

Numbness, rage, Christmas specials, and egg nog. The life of a gay man in America. No family to marry into; no way to re-create the old one. I have made the right decision. To be true to myself But still - it's Christmas. I light a Christmas candle. It represents hope.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jason Sheets
Book: Turning Points
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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
Ohio State Qualifier

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